MIL-STD-1535A(USAF)
1 February 1974
Superseding
MIL-STD-1535(USAF)
1 December 1972

MILITARY STANDARD

SUPPLIER QUALITY ASSURANCE PROGRAM REQUIREMENTS

FSC MISC

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE
Washington, D. C. 20301

Supplier Quality Assurance Program Requirements

MIL-STD-1535A(USAF)

1. This Military Standard is approved for use by all activities of the Department of the Air Force.

2. Recommended corrections, additions, or deletions should be addressed to:

HQ AIR FORCE SYSTEMS COMMAND
ATTN: SDDA
ANDREWS AIR FORCE BASE
WASHINGTON, D. C. 20334

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

FOREWORD

The purpose of this standard is to establish a supplier quality assurance program to assure the quality of products, processes, and services being supplied to a prime contractor under government contracts.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

CONTENTS

		Page
1.	Scope	1
1.1	Purpose	1
1.2	Application	1
2.	Referenced Documents	1
3.	Definitions	1
3.1	Supplier	1
3.2	Group I Purchases	1
3.3	Group II Purchases	2
3.4	Group III Purchases	2
3.5	Preaward Quality Survey	2
3.6	Registered Components	2
3.7	Nonconforming Material	2
3.8	Redundant Inspection/Test	2
4.	General Requirements	2
4.1	Types of Purchases	2
4.2	Selection of Supplier	3
4.2.1	Determining the Supplier's Capability	3
4.2.2	Preaward Quality Survey of Prospective Suppliers	3
4.2.3	Periodic Audit of Suppliers	4
4.3	Supplier Rating	4
4.3.1	Supplier Rating System	4
4.3.2	Rating	4
4.4	Purchasing Data	5
4.4.1	Responsibility	5
4.4.2	Purchase Document Evaluation	5
4.4.3	Purchase Classification	6
4.5	Prime Contractor Control at Supplier's Facility	6
4.5.1	Control of Quality	6
4.5.2	Control of Registered Components	7
4.5.2.1	Government Identified	8
4.5.2.2	Contractor Identified	8
4.6	Receipt of Procured Supplies	8
4.6.1	Receiving Inspection	8
4.6.2	Discrepancy Reporting	8
4.6.2.1	Discrepant Material	8
4.6.2.2	Discrepant Purchase Documents	8
4.6.2.3	Reporting Nonconformances	9
5.	Detailed Requirements	9
6.	Notes	9
6.1	Data	9

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

SUPPLIER QUALITY ASSURANCE PROGRAM REQUIREMENTS

1. SCOPE.

1.1 Purpose. The purpose of this standard is to establish the procedures for an effective quality assurance program for government procurements involving subcontracts when MIL-Q-9858 or MIL-I-45208 and this standard are requirements of the prime contract. The prime contractor shall include the applicable portions of these requirements in purchase documents to extend to sub-tier suppliers.

1.2 Application. This standard requires the prime contractor to provide and maintain a documented quality assurance program that will assure that subcontracted supplies conform with the requirements of the contract. Nothing in this standard shall be interpreted as establishing privity of contract between the government and the prime contractor's suppliers.

2. REFERENCED DOCUMENTS.

Military Specifications

MIL-Q-9858	Quality Program Requirements
MIL-I-45208	Inspection System Requirements

Regulations

ASPR 14-101.3 ASPR 14-101.4	Armed Forces Procurement Regulations

3. DEFINITIONS.

3.1 Supplier. The terms subcontractor, supplier, vendor, seller or any other term used to identify the source from which the prime contractor obtains support are considered to be synonomous for the purpose of this standard.

3.2 Group I Purchases - This group includes (a) purchases for products or services that are either complex or have critical application and for which conformance to contract requirements cannot or should not, for economical reasons, be fully determined upon receipt, and (b) purchases requiring direct shipment from the supplier to the government.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

3.3 Group II Purchases - This group includes purchases for supplies when conformance to contract requirements may be adequately determined by the purchasing contractor upon receipt.

3.4 Group III Purchases - This group includes purchases for products or services for which there are no contractual quality requirements specified and for which requirements of this standard do not pertain.

3.5 Preaward Quality Survey - An evaluation of a prospective contractor's quality assurance capability to perform under the terms of a proposed contract.

3.6 Registered Components - Registered components are that limited number of critical components whose failure in operation would most probably be catastrophic and complex parts which, because of their past history, nature, function, or processing, have a deficiency potential warranting traceability.

3.7 Nonconforming Material - Material, parts or components that fail to conform to specified requirements of the contract or purchase document for any quality characteristic.

3.8 Redundant Inspection/Test - Any verification of a quality characteristic performed by a higher-tiered supplier or prime contractor when that quality characteristic has previously been properly verified by the sub-tiered supplier.

4. GENERAL REQUIREMENTS. During the earliest practical phase of contract performance and prior to production and award of subcontracts, the prime contractor shall establish and institute a program which, in consonance with applicable administrative and technical requirements, will assure effective control over the quality of all products, processes, and services procured by the contractor in support of government prime contracts. The management of the program shall minimize redundant inspections and maximize use of sampling techniques commensurate with suppliers' and product quality history.

4.1 Types of Purchases. The prime contractor's supplier quality assurance program shall apply to all purchases in support of government prime contracts that are either Group I or Group II as defined in this standard. The requirements for subcontractor support to the prime contractor are contained in documents identified as purchase orders, purchase requests, and other similar terms. All such documents and the products or services they describe shall be controlled in

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

accordance with this standard. The extent to which this standard is applicable to sub-tier purchases shall be described in the prime contractor's written procedures and contained in the purchase document issued to the first-tier supplier.

4.2 Selection of Supplier.

4.2.1 Determining the Supplier's Capability. The prime contractor's program shall include procedures for the determination, prior to issuance of the purchase document, of the capability of the prospective suppliers, whether existing or new, to produce the components, equipment or systems, or to supply the service in accordance with the contractual requirements. For each prospective new supplier of Group I procurements, the prime contractor shall perform a Preaward Quality System Survey as described in paragraph 4.2.2 of this standard. Satisfactory recent quality history of a product with a function and design complexity comparable to that of an intended procurement, or other sources of valid supplier quality performance, shall be an acceptable basis for issuance of a new purchase document without additional survey activity.

4.2.2 Preaward Quality Survey of Prospective Suppliers. When the prime contractor performs a Preaward Quality System Survey at the supplier's facility, the results of each Preaward Survey shall be documented for reference and serve as a basis for required corrective action. The following factors, appropriate to the supplies to be furnished, will be evaluated during the survey:

a. Manufacturing facilities.

b. Quality of inspection planning, controls, capability and management.

c. Product/commodity visibility and defect-prevention program.

d. Product/commodity performance analysis.

e. Past experience with the type of product to be supplied.

f. Capability/condition of manufacturing equipment.

g. Control of engineering drawings and changes.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

h. Control and maintenance of inspection equipment and production tools used as a medium of inspection.

i. Control of personnel certification.

j. Material storage and handling.

k. Control of nondestructive testing and special processes.

l. Control of nonconforming supplies.

m. Corrective action program.

n. Product discipline.

o. People capability.

p. Calibration capability and resources.

4.2.3 Periodic Audit of Suppliers. Each active supplier of Group I procurements shall be subjected to a periodic review to determine the need for reaudit or resurvey. This review frequency shall be defined in the prime contractor's procedures. The purpose of the reaudit or resurvey will be to determine the continued capability of the supplier to control the quality of the material or services specified by the contract.

4.3 Supplier Rating.

4.3.1 Supplier Rating System. The supplier rating system shall be devised by the prime contractor and described in written procedures. Each supplier shall be rated for his quality of performance for each type of commodity/product being procured. The system shall consider applicable inspection and test results when available from sources such as field personnel, as well as receiving inspection, and subsequent supplier-responsible line rejects. The system shall yield the necessary basic data to provide visibility of supplier quality performance and trends. These data shall be periodically updated to reflect current supplier ratings.

4.3.2 Rating. The supplier quality rating system devised must provide adequate separation and identification of suppliers having a satisfactory rating from those having other than a satisfactory or acceptable rating. The rating should be predicated on a history of quality performance.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

The supplier's quality rating shall be given consideration comparable to other performance indicators when selecting suppliers. The prime contractor's program shall describe the precautions that shall be implemented when supplies are obtained from subcontractors which are rated below the satisfactory level established in the contractor's rating system.

4.4 Purchasing Data.

4.4.1 Responsibility. The prime contractor's supplier quality assurance program shall provide for a review of purchase documents to assure that applicable quality requirements are included or referenced in the documentation for compliance by the supplier. The review shall be accomplished as early as possible in the procurement cycle to assure the incorporation of requirements applicable to the specific purchase. The office responsible for this review shall be identified in the contractor's procedures.

4.4.2 Purchase Document Evaluation. Prime contractor evaluation of the purchase documents shall be accomplished to assure that an adequate description, appropriate for the supplies or services to be provided, is included in the documentation. The evaluation shall assure instructions are included in the purchase document for the following, as appropriate:

a. Manufacturing requirements.

b. Inspection and testing.

c. Material specifications and standards.

d. Control of registered components.

e. Special qualifications, approval or certifications.

f. Nondestructive tests.

g. Control of engineering drawings and changes.

h. Applicable product and process specifications.

i. Reliability and maintainability.

j. Safety factors.

k. Preservation, packaging and packing.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

l. Material storage and handling.

m. Contractor source quality control.

n. Government source quality assurance.

o. Shipping instructions.

p. Age control.

q. Government-furnished equipment.

r. Contractor-furnished equipment.

s. Test reports.

t. Control of tool and test equipment.

u. Nonconforming supplies.

v. Control of manufacturing methods, materials and processes.

w. Applicable workmanship standards.

4.4.3 Purchase Classification. The prime contractor's supplier quality program shall provide for a classification of each purchase depending on the criticality of the product or service to be supplied. The purchases shall be classified Group I, Group II, or Group III.

4.5 Prime Contractor Control at Supplier's Facility.

4.5.1 Control of Quality. The prime contractor is responsible for assuring that all supplies and services procured from his suppliers conform to the contract requirements. To comply with this responsibility, it may be necessary to assign prime contractor quality control employees to the supplier's facility. The extent of prime contractor involvement at the supplier's facility will depend on the classification of the purchase and the supplier's demonstrated capability to conform to specified requirements. Purchases falling into the Group I classification shall be given primary consideration for the assignment of contractor source quality assurance personnel at the subcontractor's facility. The prime contractor's field representative shall be assigned functions such as the following:

a. Performing complete or sampling inspection of product characteristics.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

b. Assuring the adequacy of, and conformance to, the controls for special manufacturing processes.

c. Assuring the adequacy of, and conformance to, the controls for inspection and test equipment.

d. Verifying conformance to procedures for the control of engineering drawings and changes.

e. Determining conformance to the supplier's approved quality program and adequacy of established inspection points.

f. Evaluating the methods for controlling nonconforming material and assuring the correction of the cause of nonconformance.

g. Documenting results of evaluations and inspections performed.

h. Indicating acceptability of supplies contained in each shipment, as applicable.

4.5.2 Control of Registered Components. Registered components require strict processing control by the prime contractor and the contractor must maintain control, regardless of the location. When a registered component is purchased, the subcontractor is required to document in detail the critical methods and processes that will be used. The subcontractor must submit to the prime contractor for analysis and acceptance the following information:

a. The methods and the type of critical processing to be used (subject to limitations imposed because of proprietary information).

b. The location within the processing cycle where inspections will take place.

c. The attributes of the products which will be inspected at each inspection point.

d. The materials and methods of preservation and packaging to be used to protect the product.

e. The handling and transportation precautions necessary to protect the product.

Revision or variation to any of the above-listed controls shall not take place until the prime contractor has accepted the revision.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.5.2.1 Government Identified - Parts, components, assemblies or systems identified as "Registered Parts" in the government contract or work order shall be controlled in accordance with paragraph 4.5.2, Control of Registered Components. Documented procedures for items in this category shall be submitted to the government for approval prior to their implementation.

4.5.2.2 Contractor Identified - When not specified in the government contract or work order, the prime contractor shall be responsible for identifying and controlling registered parts in accordance with the criteria for selection, manufacture and inspection specified in paragraph 4.5.2. Detail procedures governing the manufacture, inspection, and control of registered parts identified by the prime contractor shall be documented as a part of the contractor's total quality control program and subject to review and subsequent disapproval by the government whenever they fail to accomplish their objective.

4.6 Receipt of Procured Supplies.

4.6.1 Receiving Inspection. Supplies and services produced by outside sources for incorporation in the contract end item shall be subject to inspection at time of receipt prior to further processing within the prime contractor's plant or shipment to another location. The inspections and tests to be performed shall be designed to utilize the objective quality evidence submitted by the supplier and to assure conformance to requirements of the purchase document. In addition to verifying that the supplies and services comply with requirements of the purchase document, the supplies and services will also be verified against the latest applicable engineering changes.

4.6.2 Discrepancy Reporting.

4.6.2.1 Discrepant Material. Nonconforming material shall be identified and processed in accordance with the prime contractor's procedures for controlling nonconforming material. The supplier shall be notified of the receipt of the nonconforming material in accordance with established procedures.

4.6.2.2 Discrepant Purchase Documents. Material received that conforms to requirements of the purchase document, but fails to conform to the latest applicable engineering revision, will be placed in "hold status" pending

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

notification to the responsible prime contractor's department for consideration of revising the requirements of the purchase document. Subsequent handling of the material, if nonconforming, shall be in accordance with the prime contractor's approved procedures.

4.6.2.3 Reporting Nonconformances. The prime contractor shall report the receipt of nonconforming material to the responsible supplier in accordance with established procedures. A copy of each report will be provided, or made available to, the Government Quality Assurance Representative.

5. DETAILED REQUIREMENTS. The prime contractor is responsible for complying with the requirements specified in the contract. The written procedures developed by the prime contractor for implementing requirements of this standard shall be subject to review by the Government Quality Assurance Representative, and disapproval when the contractor's procedures do not accomplish their objectives. The Government reserves the right to perform the necessary inspections, verifications, and evaluations deemed necessary to ascertain the prime contractor's conformance to requirements of this standard and the adequacy of implementing procedures.

6. NOTES.

6.1 Data. Data generated by the requirements of this standard are not intended to be delivered to the Government unless indicated in the contract on a DD Form 1423, but shall be required for "on site" inspection conformance and program validation.

Custodian
AF-10

Preparing Activity
AF-10
MISC-F-965

User Activities
AF-11, 12, 13, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 22, 26

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

INSTRUCTIONS: In a continuing effort to make our standardization documents better, the DoD provides this form for use in submitting comments and suggestions for improvements. All users of military standardization documents are invited to provide suggestions. This form may be detached, folded along the lines indicated, taped along the loose edge *(DO NOT STAPLE)*, and mailed. In block 6, be as specific as possible about particular problem areas such as wording which required interpretation, was too rigid, restrictive, loose, ambiguous, or was incompatible, and give proposed wording changes which would alleviate the problems. Enter in block 6 any remarks not related to a specific paragraph of the document. If block 7 is filled out, an acknowledgement will be mailed to you within 30 days to let you know that your comments were received and are being considered.

NOTE: This form may not be used to request copies of documents, nor to request waivers, deviations, or clarification of specification requirements on current contracts. Comments submitted on this form do not constitute or imply authorization to waive any portion of the referenced document(s) or to amend contractual requirements.

(Fold along this line)

(Fold along this line)

DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE

NO POSTAGE NECESSARY IF MAILED IN THE UNITED STATES

OFFICIAL BUSINESS
PENALTY FOR PRIVATE USE $300

BUSINESS REPLY MAIL
FIRST CLASS PERMIT NO. 73236 WASHINGTON D. C.

POSTAGE WILL BE PAID BY THE DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE

Commander, Air Force Systems Command
Attn: SDDA
Andrews AFB, Washington, DC 20334

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

(See Instructions – Reverse Side)

1. DOCUMENT NUMBER	2. DOCUMENT TITLE

3a. NAME OF SUBMITTING ORGANIZATION	4. TYPE OF ORGANIZATION *(Mark one)*
	☐ VENDOR ☐ USER ☐ MANUFACTURER ☐ OTHER *(Specify)*:
b. ADDRESS *(Street, City, State, ZIP Code)*	

5. PROBLEM AREAS

a. Paragraph Number and Wording:

b. Recommended Wording:

c. Reason/Rationale for Recommendation:

6. REMARKS

7a. NAME OF SUBMITTER *(Last, First, MI)* – Optional	b. WORK TELEPHONE NUMBER *(Include Area Code)* – Optional
c. MAILING ADDRESS *(Street, City, State, ZIP Code)* – Optional	8. DATE OF SUBMISSION *(YYMMDD)*

DD FORM 82 MAR 1426 PREVIOUS EDITION IS OBSOLETE.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-24T00:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.